

November 2026 Vital Services Protection Measure

Considering placement of a Local Funding Measure on the Ballot

Tonight's Decision:

Merced City Council is considering whether to:

- Place a proposed measure on the November 3, 2026 ballot.
- Allow Merced residents to decide the issue through a public vote.
- Approve the ballot language and election resolution.

A general tax requires voter approval before it can take effect.

Community Engagement



How we engaged the community:

- Two statistically valid surveys of Merced residents (Nov/Dec 2025 & July 2026)
- Community meetings
- Roundtable discussions with community stakeholders
- Local media interviews and public information
- Three citywide mailers inviting residents to participate in the survey
- Dedicated project webpage with updates and resources

Community engagement and polling identified the following as residents' highest priorities:

- Responding quickly to neighborhood fires and retaining firefighters
- Protecting 911 police response times and retaining qualified police officers
- Preventing gang activity and maintaining neighborhood policing
- Fixing roads and potholes
- Maintaining Merced's local quality of life
- Keeping city parks safe and clean
- Maintaining the City's ability to respond to natural disasters and medical emergencies
- Providing police and fire stations to meet the community's needs
- Protecting Merced's vital services
- Ensuring accountability through public disclosure and independent audits



Community Needs & Services Challenges

Police

Staffing remains below 2009 levels and has not kept pace with population growth.

Fire

Fire staffing is set to be reduced March 2027 by 27% due to lack of funding.

Roads Rated "Poor“

The 2022 Pavement Condition Index identified significant investment needs.

Quality of Life

Undeveloped park sites and safety concerns require additional capital and personnel resources.

As Merced continues to grow, demand for these services continues to increase while long -term funding challenges remain.

MERCED STREETS:
POOR CONDITION, URGENT NEEDS

POTHOLES AND POOR ROADS

increase wear and tear, delays, and costs.



PAVEMENT CONDITION INDEX (PCI)

COUNTYWIDE AVERAGE

57

(AT RISK)



CITY OF MERCED

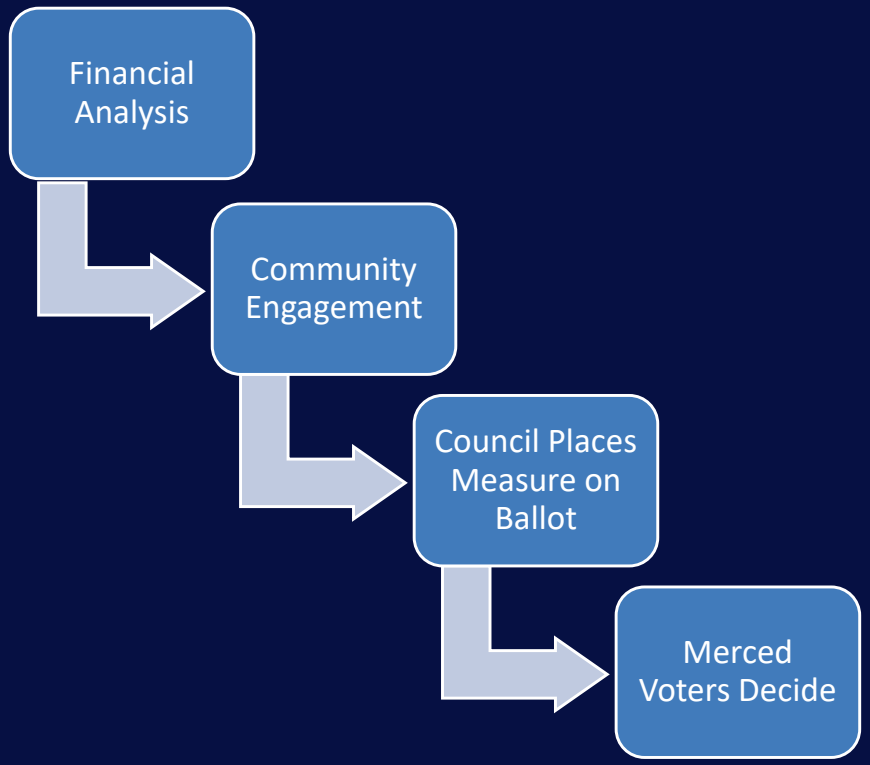
POOR

(< 50)




Proposed Vital Services Measure
1¢ Local Sales Tax
Approx $18 Million
Annually
• Local Control
• Independent Audits
• Citizen Oversight
• Public Disclosure
• Voter Approval Required

Council Consideration



Recommendation: Adopt the resolution calling the November 3, 2026 Municipal Election